El Niño Is Officially Here -- and It Could Be a Record-Breaker

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The climate phenomenon known as El Niño has officially arrived, and scientists warn it could be one for the record books. The US National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA) announced Thursday that sea surface temperatures in the central and eastern **equatorial Pacific** have crossed the 0.5°C-above-average **threshold**, meeting the criteria for an El Niño event. Even more striking is the confidence of computer models: many forecast a '**super**' El Niño, with temperatures potentially climbing more than 3°C above average by year's end. That would rival or surpass the strongest events on record 1982-83, 1997-98, and 2015-16. 'El Niño conditions developed over the past month,' NOAA stated, noting that shifting winds indicate the atmosphere is now responding to the warmer ocean. The agency urged caution, however, saying that even very strong El Niños don't guarantee impacts everywhere, but they do 'significantly tilt the odds' toward expected outcomes like **drought** in Australia and heavy rain in the southern US. The bigger concern is that this El Niño is unfolding on a planet already heated by decades of **greenhouse gas emissions**. 'The current El Niño is riding on top of a substantial amount of global warming,' said one expert. 'This means that the actual temperatures in affected regions could well be unprecedented.' A strong El Niño typically boosts global air temperatures by about 0.2°C by releasing stored ocean heat. That extra warmth now lands on a world where 2024 was the hottest year on record boosted by a relatively weak El Niño and 2025 was the third hottest despite a cooling **La Niña**. Scientists say 2027 is likely to set a new global temperature record, with disruptions to weather, food supplies, and economies extending well into that year. For now, the world watches the Pacific, waiting to see just how powerful this El Niño will become.

Word Treasure

equatorial Pacific -- The part of the Pacific Ocean near the equator where El Niño starts.

threshold -- A specific value or level that, when crossed, indicates an important change has occurred.

super -- A word used to describe an El Niño event that is extremely strong, much more powerful than normal.

drought -- A long period of very dry weather that can cause water shortages and damage crops.

greenhouse gas emissions -- Gases released into the atmosphere, like carbon dioxide from burning fossil fuels, that trap heat and warm the planet.

La Niña -- The opposite climate phase of El Niño, when tropical Pacific waters become cooler than average, often bringing different weather disruptions.

Background you need

El Niño (Spanish for 'the little boy,' referring to the Christ child) is a natural climate pattern that occurs every two to seven years when trade winds weaken, allowing warm water to slosh back toward South America. Its opposite phase, La Niña, brings cooler conditions.

The strongest El Niño on record before 2023 was 1997-98, which caused massive coral bleaching, extreme floods in parts of South America, and drought in Southeast Asia. The 2015-16 super El Niño contributed to making 2016 the hottest year on record at the time, before subsequent years surpassed it.

NOAA (the National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration) is a U.S. government agency that monitors and studies the oceans and atmosphere, issuing forecasts and warnings about climate patterns like El Niño.

The article notes that this El Niño is unfolding on a planet already warmed by decades of greenhouse gas emissions from burning coal, oil, and gas. This means the starting temperature is higher than during past strong El Niños, so even a similar event could produce much hotter extremes.

Even the 2023 La Niña, which tends to cool the globe, could not prevent 2025 from being the third-hottest year on record, showing how powerful the background warming trend has become.

Break it down

LEAD: El Niño officially arrived, scientists warn it could break records

CONDITIONS MET: Sea surface temperatures in central/eastern equatorial Pacific cross 0.5°C threshold; winds shift, atmosphere responds (NOAA statement)

FORECAST: Computer models predict a 'super' El Niño with temperatures possibly >3°C above average, rivaling 1982-83, 1997-98, 2015-16

EXPECTED IMPACTS: Tilt odds toward drought in Australia, heavy rain in southern US; NOAA cautions no guarantees

COMPOUNDING FACTOR: El Niño rides on top of global warming from greenhouse gases; expert warns affected regions could see unprecedented heat

MECHANISM: Strong El Niño releases stored ocean heat, adding ~0.2°C to global air temperatures

RECENT CONTEXT: 2024 was hottest year on record (weak El Niño), 2025 third hottest despite cooling La Niña -- only slight cooling signals long-term heat

OUTLOOK: 2027 likely to set new global temperature record, with disruptions to weather, food supplies, and economies extending well into that year

MONITORING: World watches Pacific to see how powerful this El Niño becomes

Why it matters

El Niño doesn't just change the weather for a few months -- it can disrupt food supplies, cause economic damage, and make life harder for millions of people. For a 12-14 year-old, understanding how natural cycles interact with human-caused climate change reveals why scientists warn that future extremes could be much more dangerous than in the past.

Test what you remember

1. **What sea surface temperature threshold must be crossed to declare an El Niño event?**
   - Ⓐ 1.0°C above average
   - Ⓑ 0.5°C above average
   - Ⓒ 2.0°C above average
   - Ⓓ 0.2°C above average
2. **How much above average could sea temperatures climb if a 'super' El Niño develops?**
   - Ⓐ 1.0°C
   - Ⓑ 2.0°C
   - Ⓒ More than 3.0°C
   - Ⓓ 0.5°C
3. **Which agency announced the arrival of El Niño?**
   - Ⓐ NASA
   - Ⓑ NOAA
   - Ⓒ EPA
   - Ⓓ UN
4. **What is one expected impact of El Niño mentioned in the article?**
   - Ⓐ Heavy snowfall in northern Europe
   - Ⓑ Drought in Australia
   - Ⓒ Cooler temperatures in the southern US
   - Ⓓ Reduced hurricane activity worldwide
5. **By about how much does a strong El Niño typically boost global air temperatures?**
   - Ⓐ 0.5°C
   - Ⓑ 0.2°C
   - Ⓒ 1.0°C
   - Ⓓ 0.1°C
6. **Which year is likely to set a new global temperature record according to the article?**
   - Ⓐ 2025
   - Ⓑ 2026
   - Ⓒ 2027
   - Ⓓ 2028

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: C

Questions to think about

1. Positive (Potential benefits of El Niño): In some regions, El Niño can relieve multi-year droughts, fill reservoirs, and boost agriculture. For instance, wetter conditions in parts of South America and the southern US can recharge groundwater and reduce wildfire risk. Some communities may welcome the change after prolonged dry spells.

2. Negative/Critical (Dangerous extremes amplified by warming): A super El Niño on top of record background heat could push temperatures to deadly levels in many countries, worsen water shortages, and devastate crops. The disruption to global food supplies could spike prices and cause hunger, especially in poorer nations that lack resources to adapt. This event may exceed anything seen before.

3. Neutral/Analytical (Natural cycle vs. human fingerprint): El Niño is a natural oscillation, but its impacts are now superimposed on a steep warming trend caused by greenhouse gas emissions. In the past, strong El Niños caused temporary spikes; today those spikes launch from a much higher baseline, making 'normal' weather more extreme. Studying this event will reveal how much worse future cycles can become.

4. Forward-looking (Preparation and emissions future): Better forecasting gives governments time to stockpile food, strengthen infrastructure, and warn vulnerable communities -- but the window is short. In the long run, reducing greenhouse gas emissions is essential to prevent each new El Niño from starting on an ever-hotter planet. This event might be a wake-up call for more aggressive climate policies.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):